

The Tale of Ise — BYO Reading

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Preface

Over the centuries, *The Tale of Ise* has accumulated a rich tradition of commentary and translation. These works explain difficult words, clarify relations among people and events, and provide knowledge that helps us understand the text.

Yet the more we explain, the more easily we may settle something that the text itself has left unsettled. This book tries to move in the opposite direction.

What the text does not determine, we do not rush to determine. What remains unclear may remain unclear. Where more than one reading is possible, we try to preserve that possibility.

This does not mean that anything goes. People, objects, places, times, and actions given in the text are kept in place as far as possible, without unnecessarily narrowing what can be read from them.

The Japanese title of this book is *Yomite Katte Ise Monogatari*. Its English title is *The Tale of Ise* — *BYO Reading*.

The translator decides less, so that the reader can read more.

That is what this book is for.

Dan 0 Try Reading It This Way

The Tale of Ise is sometimes said to leave too much unsaid. But does it really?

Why did someone do what they did? Who was there? Why did the next action occur? *The Tale of Ise* does not explain such things one by one.

Try approaching it a little differently.

Once a person or an object has appeared, do not make it disappear simply because it is no longer mentioned.

Who is where? What is there? What time is it? Who can see whom? What can a person do there, and what can they not do?

Keep what has already been placed in the scene where it is, and then read the next sentence.

Something that first seemed impossible to understand because “the text doesn’t say” may turn out not to require saying at all.

And one more thing.

Do not rush to supply a reason the text does not give.

“She cried because she was sad.” “He left because he was embarrassed.” “They could not speak because they did not understand each other.”

Explanations like these quickly make a story easier to understand. But if the text does not say so, try reading without supplying the explanation first.

Follow only what the characters actually do, and you may find yourself thinking, “I like this person,” “This man is pretty good,” or “Why show up now?”

A character begins to take shape on your side of the text.

That is enough.

This is why the Japanese title of this book is *Yomite Katte Ise Monogatari*.

The less the translator decides, the more the reader is free to read.

The translations in this book likewise try not to build one particular reading into the text as the correct answer.

What remains unclear may remain unclear. Where more than one reading is possible, we try to leave more than one reading possible.

First, put the people and things in place.

Then ask what can happen there.

The Tale of Ise may not leave as much unsaid as we thought.

Dan 1 Newly Crowned

- (1) mukashi wotoko uwikouburi shi te nara no miyako kasuga no sato ni shiru yoshi
past man first-crowning do CONJ Nara GEN capital Kasuga GEN village LOC know tie
shi te kari ni i ni keri
do CONJ hunting PURP go PERF PST

L: Once upon a time, a man, newly crowned, went hunting in the village of Kasuga in Nara.

N: Once upon a time, a young man, having just come of age, went hunting in the village of Kasuga in Nara.

R: Once upon a time, a man had just come of age. Through a connection, he went hunting in the village of Kasuga in Nara.

- (2) sono sato ni ito namamei taru wonna harakara sumi keri
that village LOC very elegant PERF female sibling live PST

L: In that village, very elegant female siblings lived.

N: In that village, there lived sisters of remarkable elegance.

R: In that village, there lived sisters of remarkable elegance.

- (3) kono wotoko kaima mi te keri
this man gap see CONJ PST

L: This man saw through a gap.

N: This man caught a glimpse through a gap.

R: This man caught sight of the sisters through a gap.

- (4) omohoe zu furusato ni ito hashitanaku te ari kere ba kokochi madohi ni
be-thought NEG old-capital LOC very out-of-place CONJ be PST CONJ feeling be-confused PERF
keri
PST

L: Unexpectedly, in the old capital, being very out of place, his feeling became confused.

N: Unexpectedly, it seemed very out of place in the old capital, and his feelings were thrown into confusion.

R: Unexpectedly, the sisters seemed very out of place in the old capital, and this man was thrown into confusion.

- (5) wotoko no ki tari keru kariginu no suso wo kiri te uta wo kaki te yaru
man GEN wear PERF PST hunting-robe GEN hem ACC cut CONJ poem ACC write CONJ send

L: The man cut the hem of the hunting robe he had been wearing, wrote a poem, and sent it.

N: The man cut off the hem of the hunting robe he was wearing, wrote a poem on it, and sent it.

R: He cut off the hem of the hunting robe he was wearing, wrote a poem on it, and sent it.

- (6) sono wotoko shinobuzuri no kariginu wo namu ki tari keru
that man Shinobuzuri GEN hunting-robe ACC EMPH wear PERF PST

L: That man had been wearing a hunting robe of Shinobuzuri.

N: The man was wearing a hunting robe in the Shinobuzuri pattern.

R: That hunting robe was in the Shinobuzuri pattern.

- (7) kasugano no wakamurasaki no suri goromo shinobu no midare kagiri shira re zu
Kasuga-field GEN young-purple GEN print robe Shinobu GEN disorder limit know PASS NEG

L: The printed robe of young purple from Kasuga Field; the disorder of Shinobu knows no limit.

N: A robe printed with the young purple of Kasuga Field. The disorder of Shinobu knows no bounds.

R: A robe printed with the young purple of Kasuga Field. The disorder of Shinobu knows no bounds.

- (8) to namu ohi tsuki te ihi yari keru
QUOT EMPH chase reach CONJ say send PST

L: Thus, having caught up, he sent the words.

N: He composed these words, caught up, and sent them.

R: With these words, he caught up and sent the poem.

- (9) tsui te omoshiroki koto to mo ya omohi ke mu
attach CONJ interesting matter QUOT also Q think PST FUT

L: About it; perhaps he also thought it an interesting matter.

N: Perhaps he found it interesting too.

R: Perhaps he found it interesting too.

- (10) michinoku no shinobu moizuri tare yuwe ni midare some ni shi ware nara
Michinoku GEN Shinobu twist-print who reason DAT be-disordered begin PERF PST I be
naku ni
NEG CONJ

L: The Shinobu-moizuri of Michinoku - because of whom did it begin to be disordered, though it was not I?

N: The Shinobu-moizuri of Michinoku - because of whom did it begin to be disordered? It was not because of me.

R: The Shinobu-moizuri of Michinoku - because of whom did it begin to be disordered? It was not because of me.

- (11) to ifu uta no kokorobae nari
QUOT say poem GEN disposition be

L: It is the disposition of the poem that says so.

N: It is the conception of that poem.

R: It is the conception of that poem.

- (12) mukashibito ha kaku ichihayaki miyabi wo namu shi keru
people-of-past TOP thus intense courtly-elegance ACC EMPH do PST

L: People of the past did such swift courtly elegance.

N: People of the past practiced such light and witty courtly elegance.

R: People of the past practiced such light and witty courtly elegance.

Commentary

I will start the commentary of the main text from here.